

Katherine Johnson

The Girl Who Counted Her Way Forward

The true story of a girl who counted everything, faced unfair rules, and grew up to check the numbers that sent astronauts safely into space and home again.

Before reading

Look at the cover. What is in the sky behind Katherine? What might counting have to do with rockets?

While reading

1. What did Katherine count when she was little?
2. Why did Katherine's family move every school year?
3. What did astronaut John Glenn ask Katherine to do?

After reading

1. Some rules in Katherine's time were unfair. What does "fair" mean to you?
2. Katherine asked, "Is there a law against it?" and went to the meeting. When have you spoken up?
3. Why is it important to check your work?

The big idea

Count it. Check it. Check again!

Use it for everyday maths: laying the table, counting stairs or sharing snacks.

Try this together

A counting hunt. Pick a number, such as 7. Your child finds 7 of something around the house, then someone else checks the count. Swap roles!

Words to talk about

count · check · mathematician · astronaut · spacecraft · orbit

Tips for reading aloud: pause on the pictures and let children notice details first. There are no wrong answers to these questions; follow your child's curiosity. The back of the book has four simple experiments to try, and a free activity pack is at tarkasatales.com/activities.

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